

Communicable Diseases and Their Spread

Air-borne, water/food-borne and insect-borne diseases — what causes them and how to stop them.

Know your common diseases

All communicable diseases are caused by **pathogens**. Here are the common ones grouped by how they spread.

Spread through air

Disease	Caused by
Common cold & influenza (flu)	Virus
Chickenpox, Measles	Virus
Tuberculosis (TB)	Bacteria

Spread through contaminated water/food

Disease	Caused by
Hepatitis A	Virus
Cholera, Typhoid	Bacteria
Ascariasis (roundworm)	Worms

Spread by insects (vectors)

Disease	Caused by
Malaria	Protozoa
Dengue	Virus

Prevention toolkit: wash hands with soap, cover mouth/nose when coughing, wear a mask in crowds, don't share towels, drink boiled/clean water, eat properly cooked food, use mosquito nets/repellents, and rest at home when ill.

Where students lose marks

Trap 1 — Malaria is caused by a protozoan, dengue by a virus. Both are spread by mosquitoes, but the pathogens differ.

Trap 2 — TB is bacterial, not viral. Cold, flu, chickenpox, measles, dengue and hepatitis A are viral; TB, cholera and typhoid are bacterial.

Trap 3 — Match prevention to spread. Boiling water prevents water-borne disease; masks/covering the mouth prevent air-borne disease; nets prevent vector-borne disease.

Model answers — write them like this

Example A. Name the causal agent of (i) malaria (ii) typhoid (iii) chickenpox.

Step 1: Recall the group of each pathogen.

∴ (i) protozoa (ii) bacteria (iii) virus.

Example B. Two precautions to prevent cholera.

Step 1: Cholera spreads through contaminated water/food.

∴ Drink boiled/clean water and eat properly cooked food; maintain hygiene.

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